

Dear Editors,

We are pleased to submit our manuscript entitled "*The biodiversity we ignore: a global meta-analysis on taxonomic bias*" for consideration as a Letter in *Ecology Letters*.

Taxonomic bias – the preferential focus on charismatic or familiar species – has been widely documented across ecology and conservation. Yet despite widespread concern, we lack a quantitative synthesis of its prevalence, magnitude, and consequences across the Tree of Life. Our meta-analysis addresses this gap by synthesizing 905 effect sizes from 78 studies spanning three decades of global research.

Our findings challenge prevailing assumptions while revealing a critical blind spot. Taxonomic bias is indeed pervasive: vertebrates dominate research attention while plants, invertebrates, and microorganisms remain systematically underrepresented. However, effect sizes are generally modest (most Pearson's $r < 0.5$), suggesting that while the playing field is tilted, the overall research enterprise is not catastrophically distorted. The exception – and possibly our most concerning finding – is conservation priority. Research effort and public interest do not systematically align with species facing the greatest extinction risk. The charismatic continue to win attention, whether or not they need it most.

We believe this manuscript aligns well with *Ecology Letters*' emphasis on synthetic work addressing fundamental questions in ecology and conservation: 1) it is the first global synthesis quantifying taxonomic bias across multiple dimensions (appearance, commonness, conservation status, utilitarian value), revealing which factors most shape ecological research agendas; 2) Our findings have immediate relevance for research prioritization, funding allocation, and global biodiversity assessment efforts.

We have submitted this as a *Letter*, as it presents a primary research meta-analysis with novel quantitative findings. However, we recognize the work also synthesizes a broad literature and offers forward-looking recommendations, which might align with a *Perspective* or *Review* format. We welcome your guidance on the most appropriate article type.

This manuscript has not been published elsewhere and is not under consideration by another journal. All authors have approved the submission. Thank you for considering our work. We welcome your feedback and look forward to your decision.

Sincerely,

Dr. Stefano Mammola (On behalf of all co-authors)

Suggested referees:

Masashi Soga – masashi.soga.mail@gmail.com (reason: expert on human-nature interactions)

Joaquin Hortal – jhortal@mncn.csic.es (reason: expert on various form of bias)

Duarte Gonçalves – duartenvg@gmail.com (reason: expert on taxonomic bias, especially regarding fungi)

Elena Gazzea – e.gazzea@gmail.com (reason: expert on meta-analyses)